How Economists Discuss Central Bank Digital Currencies

Themes, Tone and Stance, 2014–2026

Adriel Mazere*

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Abstract

Keywords:
JEL codes:

1 Introduction

2 Related literature

2.1 Central bank digital currencies

2.2 What the field builds on

2.3 Bibliometric and text-as-data studies of CBDCs

Within our corpus, we observe 29 titles that announce a literature, systematic or bibliometric review of CBDCs, published between 2019 and 2026. When comparing the five most recent bibliometric studies with ours, we found three shared main limits. First, their data come from one or two databases, Scopus and/or Web of Science, and are mostly journal papers written in English. Working papers, central-bank speeches and central-bank documents are therefore mostly absent from their analysis, so that their sample is very limited compared to ours: a few hundred documents compared to 4,710. In addition, they build their analysis with standard tools that mainly describe what is studied, but not how (tone and stance) or why. Finally, their classifications are never checked against a reading of the texts themselves.

Our study addresses these three limits. Our corpus is much larger, with papers coming from five databases, central-bank speeches and documents, in different languages, and every text is checked to be written by an economist or an economic institution. We ask not only what is written but also who writes it, how, why and when. Finally, each automatic classification we use is compared with our own reading of a sample of texts.

MISSING : text-as-data studies

*M2 – Private crypto.

3 Data

3.1 Sources and collection

3.2 De-duplication and enrichment

3.3 Relevance: is CBDC the theme?

3.4 Who counts as an economist

3.5 Descriptive statistics

4 Who writes

4.1 Method: co-citation, co-authorship, bibliometric laws and distinctive vocabulary

4.2 Findings

5 What is written

5.1 Method: thematic map, topic model and covariate-adjusted shares

To see what is written by economists, we use two methods. The first one consists in grouping keywords that often appear together in the same papers into themes. Then, we place these themes on a thematic map with two axes: how much a theme is linked to the other themes (*centrality*) and how much its keywords are linked to each other (*density*). This allows us to classify themes into four types: motor, basic, niche, and emerging or declining.

The second method consists in grouping texts by their meaning. To do so, we use *SBERT*, a multilingual model that turns each title and abstract into a vector, so that two texts saying the same thing end up close, even if they are not written in the same language. We then group these vectors into 24 topics with *BERTopic* and label each topic with its most specific words.

Finally, to make sure that a change in the share of a topic is not only due to a change in who writes, we run a logit regression of each topic on the period, the type of author and the language. That allows us to measure how the share of each topic changed between two periods (here, between 2014-2019 and 2023-2026), in percentage points, all else being equal.

5.2 Findings

The thematic map shows that the CBDC literature is driven by two themes: blockchain technology and the digital transformation of financial services, together with monetary policy and payments. Fintech and digital finance form a basic theme, while digital payments, India and the cashless society are niche topics.

From our analysis, we observe a shift in the way economists discuss CBDC from 2014 to 2026. The early literature treated CBDC as a monetary policy instrument: half of the papers published before 2020 deal with monetary policy and its economic impact, against a fifth today. The topic model shows the same trend, as the topic on interest rates and uncertainty decreases by 9.6 points. Early papers also often discussed CBDC together with private cryptocurrencies: the largest topic of the period is characterized by words such as *cryptocurrencies* and *private*, and it is also the topic that lost the most ground since then (−13.2 points).

After 2020, as central banks started to work on their own projects, the discussion became more national. The digital euro and the digital ruble, almost absent before 2020, now appear in 11% and 15% of the papers, and *euro*, *ruble* and *India* are among the words that best characterize recent years. At the

same time, financial inclusion is the theme that grows the fastest, from 6% to 16% of the papers. Overall, the literature moved from general questions on the effects of a CBDC to questions on specific national projects and on who they are meant for.

6 How economists discuss CBDCs: tone and stance

6.1 Method: tone (FinBERT) and stance (reading and a local language model)

6.2 Findings

6.3 Do policy events move the tone?

7 Why: stated motivations

7.1 Method: a validated codebook

7.2 Findings

8 When: the policy environment

8.1 Method: bursts, event study with placebo dates, difference-in-differences

8.2 Findings

9 The discussion and its environment

9.1 Period by period

9.2 What can and cannot be said about causes

10 Robustness

11 Discussion

11.1 Limitations

12 Conclusion

Data and code availability

A Search vocabulary

B Harvesting algorithms

C Validation samples and coding guide

D Additional tables and figures